Chronology — Year-Wise Major Events (Ancient India)

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Prehistoric cultures | Indus / Harappan phases | Vedic age | Mahajanapadas & Magadha | Buddhism–Jainism | Foreign invasions | Mauryas | Post-Mauryan | Kushanas | Guptas | Harsha | South India spine | Arrange drills

Sources baked in: NCERT Class 6–12 Ancient spines, Jagran Josh / Lucent-style year lists, Spectrum coaching dates, Wikipedia Timeline of Indian history (PCS-relevant entries only) **Weight:** ★★★ for arrange-order and dynasty–ruler ladders **Last verified:** September 2026 **Voice:** Full event phrases — same density style as Modern chronology. Approximate BCE dates use **c.** where scholars disagree.

A.0 Megaspine — memorise this first

Year	Event
c. 2600–1900 BCE	Mature Harappan urban phase
c. 1500–1000 BCE	Early Vedic (Rigvedic) age
c. 1000–600 BCE	Later Vedic age
c. 600 BCE	Sixteen Mahajanapadas; Magadha rises
c. 563 / 483 BCE	Birth / Mahaparinirvana of the Buddha (traditional)
326 BCE	Alexander invades; Battle of the Hydaspes
c. 321 BCE	Chandragupta Maurya founds the Mauryan Empire
c. 261 BCE	Ashoka's Kalinga War
185 BCE	Pushyamitra Shunga ends Mauryan rule
78 CE	Beginning of the Saka Era
c. 319–320 CE	Beginning of the Gupta Era; Chandragupta I
c. 375–415 CE	Chandragupta II Vikramaditya; Fa-Hien visits
606–647 CE	Harshavardhana of Kannauj; Xuanzang visits

A.1 Prehistoric India

Year	Event
Palaeolithic	Lower, Middle and Upper Palaeolithic cultures; Soan Valley and Bhimbetka sequence in coaching maps
Mesolithic	Microlithic tools; hunting-gathering with early domestication at some sites; rock art continuity
Neolithic	Settled agriculture and pottery; Mehrgarh as the classic early farming settlement
Chalcolithic	Copper + stone cultures across the Deccan, Rajasthan and Gangetic fringe
Iron Age / NBPW	Spread of iron; Northern Black Polished Ware linked to second urbanisation and Magadha

A.2 Indus / Harappan Civilization

Year	Event
c. 3300–2600 BCE	Early Harappan / regionalisation phase; early Indus script signs appear
c. 2800 BCE	Harappa and Mohenjo-daro grow into major urban centres in coaching timelines
c. 2600–1900 BCE	Mature Harappan — planned cities, baked brick, drainage, seals, craft specialisation, long-distance trade
c. 1900–1300 BCE	Late Harappan / decline and localisation; Cemetery H and related cultures
Key sites	Harappa, Mohenjo-daro, Dholavira, Lothal, Kalibangan, Rakhigarhi, Banawali — learn site↔feature matches separately in Topic 2

A.3 Vedic Age

Year	Event
c. 1500–1000 BCE	Early Vedic / Rigvedic age; pastoral Jana polity; composition of the Rigveda
c. 1200–1000 BCE	Kuru polity emerges as an important Later Vedic political centre in many reconstructions
c. 1000–600 BCE	Later Vedic age; expansion into the Ganga valley; territorial janapadas; varna order hardens
c. 700–500 BCE	Composition and teaching of major Upanishads; end of the classical Vedic period in broad keys

Year	Event
c. 700 BCE	Kosala and other eastern kingdoms strengthen within the Northern Black Polished Ware world

A.4 Mahajanapadas, Jainism & Buddhism

Year	Event
c. 600 BCE	Sixteen Mahajanapadas listed in the Anguttara Nikaya; Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa and Avanti as the Big Four
c. 599 BCE	Traditional birth of Mahavira, 24th Tirthankara of Jainism
c. 563 BCE	Traditional birth of Siddhartha Gautama (the Buddha) at Lumbini
c. 544–492 BCE	Bimbisara of the Haryanka dynasty rules Magadha; contemporary of Buddha and Mahavira
c. 527 BCE	Traditional nirvana / moksha of Mahavira
c. 492–460 BCE	Ajatashatru rules Magadha; fortifies Rajagriha; conflicts with Vajji / Licchavi
c. 483 BCE	Traditional Mahaparinirvana of the Buddha at Kushinagar
c. 483 BCE	First Buddhist Council at Rajagriha under Ajatashatru
c. 383 BCE	Second Buddhist Council at Vaishali
c. 413–345 BCE	Shishunaga dynasty controls Magadha after the Haryankas
c. 345–321 BCE	Nanda dynasty under Mahapadma Nanda and Dhana Nanda — Magadha at peak before the Mauryas
c. 350 BCE	Panini of Gandhara composes the Ashtadhyayi — classical Sanskrit grammar

A.5 Alexander & the Mauryan Empire

Year	Event
327–326 BCE	Alexander invades the north-west; Ambhi of Taxila submits
326 BCE	Battle of the Hydaspes — Alexander defeats Porus
325–324 BCE	Alexander retreats from the Beas; Macedonian hold in the north-west weakens
c. 321 BCE	Chandragupta Maurya overthrows the Nandas with Chanakya's help; capital at Pataliputra
c. 305–303 BCE	Chandragupta's war and treaty with Seleucus Nicator — north-west territories for elephants; Megasthenes later at Pataliputra

Year	Event
c. 297–273 BCE	Bindusara succeeds Chandragupta; Deccan expansion continues
c. 273 / 268 BCE	Ashoka ascends (coaching keys use either year; reign conventionally to c. 232 BCE)
c. 261 BCE	Kalinga War; Ashoka turns to Dhamma after the slaughter
c. 260–250 BCE	Ashokan Major and Minor Rock Edicts and Pillar Edicts; Buddhist missions; Third Buddhist Council tradition at Pataliputra
c. 232 BCE	Death of Ashoka; later Mauryas weaken
c. 230 BCE	Simuka founds the Satavahana power in the Deccan as Mauryan control fades
185 BCE	Pushyamitra Shunga kills Brihadratha and founds the Shunga dynasty — end of Mauryan rule

A.6 Post-Mauryan to Kushanas

Year	Event
185–73 BCE	Shunga dynasty in the Gangetic heartland; Brahmanical patronage; conflict with Indo-Greeks
c. 73–28 BCE	Kanva dynasty briefly succeeds the Shungas
c. 180–165 BCE	Indo-Greek power in the north-west; Menander (Milinda) as the most famous Indo-Greek king
57 BCE	Beginning of the Vikrama Era (coaching calendar tag)
c. 1st cent. BCE – 3rd cent. CE	Satavahana Empire in the Deccan; conflict and exchange with the Shakas
30 BCE / 1st cent. CE	Early historic Tamilakam — Chera, Chola, Pandya; Sangam literature phase
78 CE	Beginning of the Saka Era
c. 1st–3rd cent. CE	Shaka Kshatrapas in western India; Kushana Empire from Central Asia into the plains
c. 78 / 127 CE	Kanishka's accession (date debated); Kushana zenith; Gandhara–Mathura art; Fourth Buddhist Council tradition
c. 100 CE	Charaka Samhita tradition — classical Ayurveda compilation associated with this era in coaching keys

A.7 Gupta Age

Year	Event
c. 240–280 CE	Sri Gupta and early Guptas as local Magadha rulers
c. 319–320 CE	Chandragupta I; beginning of the Gupta Era; marriage alliance with the Licchavis
c. 335–375 CE	Samudragupta's conquests; Allahabad / Prayaga Prashasti of Harishena; Vincent Smith's "Indian Napoleon" tag
c. 345 CE	Mayurasharma founds the Kadamba kingdom at Banavasi
c. 375–415 CE	Chandragupta II Vikramaditya (विक्रमादित्य); defeat of western Shakas; court of the Navaratnas; age of **Kalidasa** (कालिदास) in coaching keys
c. 399–414 CE	Fa-Hien (Faxian) travels in Gupta India
c. 415–455 CE	Kumaragupta I; title Mahendraditya; Nalanda's early growth under Gupta patronage
c. 455–467 CE	Skandagupta faces the Hunas
476 CE	Birth of Aryabhata — Aryabhatiya; place-value and astronomical work
c. 467–550 CE	Later Guptas weaken; Huna pressure; regional break-up
c. 528 CE	Yashodharman and allied rulers defeat Mihirakula's Hunas at the Battle of Sondani
c. 550 CE	Imperial Gupta power effectively ends

A.8 Harsha & late ancient South

Year	Event
c. 550–606 CE	Post-Gupta regional kingdoms; Rise of Pushyabhuti power at Thanesar
606 CE	Harshavardhana crowned; later rules from Kannauj
c. 630–644 CE	Xuanzang (Hiuen Tsang) travels in India; describes Harsha and Nalanda
c. 634–637 CE	Pulakeshin II of Badami Chalukyas checks Harsha on the Narmada
628 CE	Brahmagupta completes the Brahmasphutasiddhanta
647 CE	Death of Harsha; rapid fragmentation of north India — early medieval transition
Pallavas	Kanchipuram capital; Mahendravarman I and Narasimhavarman I; rock-cut to structural temples

Year	Event
Badami Chalukyas	Pulakeshin II’s peak; conflict with Pallavas and Harsha
c. 753 CE	Dantidurga founds the Rashtrakuta kingdom of Manyakhet — counted with early medieval south